

Study Note

COMMUNICATING IN TEAMS AND MASTERING LISTENING AND NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION SKILLS

BUS201: Business and Human Communication

**Communicating in Teams and Mastering Listening and Nonverbal
Communication Skills**

Topic 2 | Week 2

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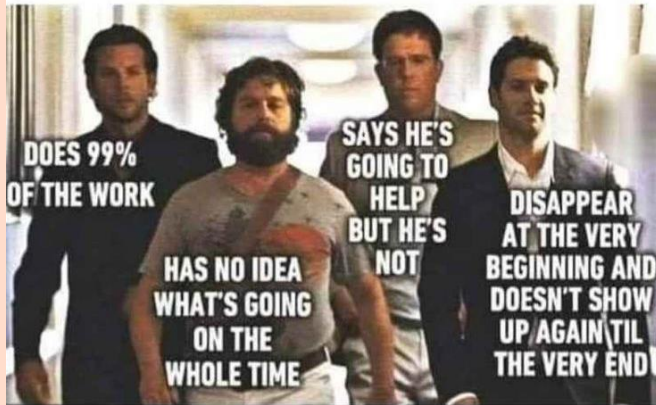
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EVERY WORKPLACE TEAM



COMMUNICATING EFFECTIVELY IN TEAMS

Collaboration — working together to meet complex challenges — is a prime skill expected in a wide range of professions. A **team** is a unit of two or more people who share a mission and the responsibility for working to achieve their goal. Some teams meet and work together in person; others are virtual teams, whose members work in different locations and interact through one or more digital channels.

Advantages and Disadvantages of Teams

Teams can provide businesses and individuals with a variety of benefits.

- ⊕ **More information and knowledge.** By pooling the experience of several individuals, a team has access to more information during the decision-making process.
- ⊕ **Learning opportunities.** Teams that bring together people with various work special ties give people the chance to learn from each other.
- ⊕ **Boldness.** People who might hesitate to take calculated risks on their own may be more willing to make bold moves as part of a team.
- ⊕ **Accountability.** Most people want to avoid letting others down, and participating in teams creates a built-in sense of accountability to others.
- ⊕ **Trust building.** Working closely in teams lets people develop trust in their colleagues, which can be beneficial outside the confines of the team activities as well.
- ⊕ **A broader range of viewpoints.** Diverse teams in particular can bring a variety of perspectives that improve decision making.
- ⊕ **Buy-in for solutions the team creates.** Those who participate in making a decision are more likely to support it and encourage others to accept it.
- ⊕ **Improved performance.** Effective teams can be better than top-performing individuals at solving complex problems.
- ⊕ **A sense of community in good times and bad.** Being on a team helps individuals share in the celebration of successes and provides emotional support during challenging periods.

Although teamwork has many advantages, teams need to be aware of and work to counter the following potential disadvantages.

- ⊕ **Groupthink.** Like other social structures, business teams can generate tremendous pressure to conform. **Groupthink** occurs when peer pressure causes individual team members to withhold contrary opinions and to go along with decisions they don't really believe in. The consequences of groupthink can range from bland, unimaginative work to outright disasters.
- ⊕ **Hidden agendas.** Some team members may have a hidden agenda — a private, counterproductive motive, such as a desire to take control of the group, to undermine someone else on the team, or to pursue an incompatible goal.
- ⊕ **Cost.** Aligning schedules, arranging meetings, and coordinating individual parts of a project can consume a lot of time and money.

- ⊕ **Overload.** Some companies have embraced collaborative work approaches to such an extent that they're overloading employees with team assignments.

Characteristics of Effective Teams

A wide variety of factors can account for team success, but here are the most significant that researchers have identified.

A shared sense of purpose and compatible values	A clear and challenging goal
A belief in the value of the team's efforts	A well-balanced mix of people who can provide the insights and skills needed to achieve the goal
Positive behavioral norms that promote psychological safety, encouraging people to share information, propose unproven ideas, and express vulnerability without fear of repercussion	A willingness to put the team's needs ahead of individual needs
Open and honest communication	Conflict Resolution

Notice how all of these traits rely on communication, both in the information that is shared and the way people interact with one another.

Conflict Resolution in Team Settings

Conflict in team settings can be beneficial if it brings important issues to light, increases team involvement, or generates creative solutions. Diverse perspectives help teams avoid groupthink and foster creativity. For instance, assigning members different problem-solving roles (cautious, daring, logical, creative) can lead to a deeper understanding and better responses.

However, **conflict becomes destructive when it drains energy, lowers morale, or divides the team.** It often stems from disagreements over goals, personal animosity, or deep-seated differences. To maintain productivity, teams must prevent or quickly resolve destructive conflict.

Conflict management styles are the different ways that individuals address, engage in and resolve conflict. According to the Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument (TKI), there are five major conflict management styles.

Conflict Management Styles



1. Avoiding (Unassertive and Uncooperative)

In avoiding, individuals sidestep conflict, hoping it will resolve itself or be handled by others. It's often used when the issue is minor or when more information is needed.

Example: Jake and Amy have been collaborating on the new UX design for weeks. The deadline is looming and they are increasingly unable to agree on changes. The deadline is pushed back and they both are given the day to work on other projects. The space to take a break from each other, as well as the extra time to complete their project, allows them to cool down and resume in a more collaborative mindset.

2. Competing/Forcing (Assertive and Uncooperative)

In competing or forcing, one party pursues their own concerns at the expense of others, often using power or authority to win the conflict.

Example: A senior manager pushes their decision on a marketing strategy without considering input from the rest of the team, believing their way is best. Others may feel overlooked or demotivated as a result.

3. Accommodating (Unassertive and Cooperative)

In accommodating, individuals give in to others' demands, sometimes at their own expense, to maintain harmony or good relations.

Example: In a marketing meeting, the colors for the new Summer campaign are being discussed. Raymond is adamant that choice A is the best choice. Gina thinks that choice B is slightly better, but decides to let Raymond choose the colors, to avoid arguing about two choices that she thinks are both fine.

4. Compromising (Moderately Assertive and Cooperative)

Compromising involves finding a middle ground where both parties give up something to reach a mutually acceptable solution.

Example: Rosa and Charles are in charge of the advertising budget for the next quarter. Rosa wants to hire a full-time social media person, while Charles wants to increase targeted digital ads. A compromise is reached by hiring a social media person to work part-time, with the remainder of the budget being spent on digital advertising.

5. Collaborating (Assertive and Cooperative)

In collaborating, both parties work together to find a solution that fully satisfies everyone's concerns. It requires open communication and shared problem-solving.

Example: Terry and Janet are leading the design of a new prototype. They are having difficulties, as Terry wants to incorporate a specific set of features. Janet wants to incorporate a different set of features. To reach a solution, they sit down, talk through each feature, why it is (or isn't) important, and finally reach a solution, incorporating a mix of their features and some new ones they realized were important as they negotiated.

Each style can be effective depending on the situation, but using the right approach for the right context is key to successful conflict resolution in business.

MAKING YOUR MEETINGS MORE PRODUCTIVE

Well-run meetings can help companies solve problems, develop ideas, and identify opportunities. Meetings can also be a great way to promote team building through the experience of social interaction. To a large degree, your ability to contribute to the company — and to be recognized for your contributions — will depend on your meeting skills.

Preparing for Meetings

The first step in preparing for a meeting is to make sure the meeting is really necessary. Meetings can consume hundreds or thousands of dollars' worth of productive time and take people away from other work, so don't hold a meeting if some other form of communication can serve the purpose as effectively or if you can't clearly articulate what the meeting is supposed to achieve. If a meeting is truly necessary, proceed with these four planning tasks.

- ⊕ **Clarify your purpose.** Most meetings are one of two types: **Informational meetings** involve sharing information and perhaps coordinating action. **Decision-making meetings** involve analysis, problem solving, and in many cases, persuasive communication. Whatever your purpose, make sure it is clear and specific — and clearly communicated to all participants.
- ⊕ **Select participants for the meeting.** The rule here is simple: Invite everyone who really needs to be involved, and don't invite anyone who doesn't. For decision-making meetings, for example, invite only those people who are in a direct position to help the meeting reach its objective.
- ⊕ **Choose the venue and the time.** Online meetings are often the best way (and sometimes the only way) to connect people in multiple locations or to reach large audiences. For on-site meetings, review the facility and the seating arrangements. Are rows of chairs suitable, or do you need a conference table or some other arrangement? Pay attention to room temperature, lighting, ventilation, acoustics, and refreshments. These details can determine the success or failure of a meeting. If you have control over the timing, morning meetings are often more productive because people are generally more alert and not yet engaged with the work of the day.

- ⊕ **Set and share the agenda.** People who will be presenting information need to know what is expected of them, nonpresenters need to know what will be presented so they can prepare questions, and everyone needs to know how long the meeting will last. In addition, the agenda is an important tool for guiding the progress of the meeting.

Conducting and Contributing to Efficient Meetings

Everyone in a meeting shares the responsibility for keeping the meeting productive and making it successful. If you are the designated leader of a meeting, however, you have an extra degree of responsibility and accountability. To ensure productive meetings, be sure to do the following.

- ⊕ **Keep the meeting on track.** A good meeting draws out the best ideas and information the group has to offer. Good leaders occasionally need to guide, mediate, probe, stimulate, summarize, and redirect discussions that have gotten off track. Don't leave it all in the leader's hands, however; everyone should help keep the meeting focused and moving forward.
- ⊕ **Follow agreed-upon rules.** The larger the meeting, the more formal you'll need to be to maintain order. Formal meetings often use *parliamentary procedure*, a time-tested method for planning and running effective meetings. The best-known guide to this procedure is *Robert's Rules of Order* (www.rulesonline.com).
- ⊕ **Encourage and moderate participation.** Some people like to think out loud, using discussion to help clarify their own thoughts. Others prefer to finalize their thoughts before speaking. Effective meeting leaders need to accommodate both styles, in addition to making sure that people who may not feel comfortable speaking up or who have been interrupted by more assertive participants have the chance to be heard.
- ⊕ **Participate actively.** Try to contribute to the progress of the meeting and the smooth interaction of the participants. Use your listening skills and powers of observation to judge the interpersonal dynamics of the group, then adapt your behavior to help the group achieve its goals. Speak up if you have something useful to say, but don't talk or ask questions just to demonstrate how much you know about the subject at hand.
- ⊕ **Don't interrupt.** Even if you're an expert in the subject matter or the discussion is getting heated, respect everyone's right to participate. Meetings can be dominated by the most aggressive participants, but the loudest people don't necessarily have the best ideas.
- ⊕ **Use mobile devices respectfully.** Tweeting key points from a convention speech or using your phone to jot down essential ideas and follow-up questions can be productive and respectful ways to use a device during a meeting. Checking Facebook or working on unrelated tasks is not. If you intend to use your device to take notes during a meeting, consider letting the meeting leader know that's what you're doing.
- ⊕ **Close effectively.** At the conclusion of a meeting, verify that the objectives have been met. If they have not, arrange for follow-up work as needed. Either summarize the decisions reached or list the actions to be taken. Make sure all participants understand and agree on the outcome.

LISTENING

You've been listening all your life, so it's natural to assume it's something you do well without even thinking about it. However, listening is a far more complex process than most people think — and most of us aren't very good at it. People typically listen at no better than a 25 percent efficiency rate, remember only about half of what's said during a 10-minute conversation, and forget half of that within 48 hours. Furthermore, when questioned about material they've just heard, they are likely to get the facts mixed up. The good news is that everyone can improve their listening skills, and doing so will help you at every step of your career.

The Listening Process

Listening is not a simple process that happens automatically; truly hearing what other people say requires effort and attention. Listening follows the same sequence as the basic communication process model, with the added difficulty that it happens in real time. To listen effectively, you need to successfully complete five steps.



1. **Receiving.** Physically hearing the message and recognizing it as incoming information.
2. **Decoding.** Assigning meaning to sounds, according to your own values, beliefs, ideas, expectations, roles, needs, and personal history.
3. **Remembering.** Storing the information for future processing.
4. **Evaluating.** Analyzing the quality of the information.
5. **Responding.** Reacting based on the situation and the nature of the information.

If any one of these steps breaks down, the listening process becomes less effective or even fails entirely. As both a sender and a receiver, you can reduce the failure rate by recognizing and overcoming a variety of physical and mental barriers to effective listening.

Barriers to Listening

Good listeners look for ways to overcome the many potential barriers to successful listening. Some factors you may not be able to control, such as ambient noise or poor phone reception. However, you can control other factors, such as not interrupting speakers, not multitasking when someone is talking to you, and not creating distractions that make it difficult for others to pay attention. And don't think that you're not interrupting just because you're not talking. Such actions as sighing or checking your watch can interrupt a speaker and lead to communication breakdowns.

Selective listening is one of the most common barriers to effective listening. If you don't pay attention the entire time someone is speaking, you will be unable to recall what the speaker actually said. Instead, you'll remember what you think the speaker probably said.

For example, imagine a manager in a meeting discussing new work policies. While the HR representative is explaining the importance of following a particular policy on time-off requests, the manager, already feeling overwhelmed, tunes out part of the explanation. Later, the manager only recalls the part about deadlines for requests, missing the details about how the policy impacts scheduling and approval processes. As a result, they miscommunicate the policy to their team.

Overcoming interpretation barriers can be difficult because you may not even be aware of them. **Selective perception** leads listeners to mold messages to fit their own conceptual frameworks. Listeners sometimes make up their minds before fully hearing the speaker's message, or they engage in **defensive listening** — protecting their egos by rejecting anything that doesn't confirm their beliefs or their view of themselves.

For example, a salesperson attends a training session about improving customer service, but they already believe their approach is the best. When the trainer suggests adopting a more consultative selling style, the salesperson dismisses this advice, interpreting it as unnecessary or irrelevant. Instead of listening carefully, they selectively hear only the parts that confirm their own approach, ignoring tips that could improve their performance. This defensive attitude keeps them from growing and adapting to new methods.

Even when your intentions are good, you can still misinterpret incoming messages if you and the speaker don't share enough language or experience. When listening to a speaker whose native language or life experience is different from yours, try to paraphrase that person's ideas. Give the speaker a chance to confirm what you think you heard or to correct any misinterpretation.

Effective Listening

By applying the following techniques, you can improve your listening skills and enhance communication in both professional and personal contexts.

1. **Find areas of interest.** Even if a topic seems boring or irrelevant, look for aspects that relate to your goals or interests to stay engaged.
2. **Focus on content.** Pay attention to the message itself, not just the delivery. Concentrate on the ideas being communicated rather than how they are presented.
3. **Hold your fire.** Don't jump to conclusions or interrupt. Wait until the speaker has finished before forming an opinion or responding.
4. **Listen for ideas.** Instead of getting bogged down by details, focus on the overall concepts and key takeaways the speaker is trying to convey.
5. **Take selective notes.** Jot down the most important points, not every word. This helps you stay focused and process information better.

6. **Work at listening.** Listening is an active process, requiring effort and attention. Don't let your mind wander; stay engaged in the conversation.
7. **Block competing thoughts.** Clear your mind of distractions, such as personal worries or preoccupations, to fully focus on what the speaker is saying.
8. **Paraphrase the speaker.** Restate what the speaker said in your own words to ensure you've understood their message correctly and to show active engagement.
9. **Stay open-minded.** Keep an open mind, even if you disagree with the speaker, and be willing to consider new perspectives.
10. **Stay ahead of the speaker.** Anticipate where the speaker is going with their message without jumping to conclusions, so you can follow along with the flow of ideas.

TELEPHONE ETIQUETTES

Receiving Telephone Calls

By adopting the following steps, you can handle telephone calls professionally and effectively, ensuring clear communication and a positive experience for the caller.

1. **Answer promptly:** When a call comes in, answer it as quickly as possible, ideally within three rings. This shows professionalism and attentiveness, creating a good first impression.
2. **Identify yourself:** After answering, clearly state your name and, if applicable, the name of the organization or department. This lets the caller know they've reached the correct person or place.
Example: "Good morning, this is John from Customer Support. How can I assist you?"
3. **Establish rapport:** Begin the conversation with a warm tone and, if appropriate, some small pleasantries to make the caller feel comfortable. This can help build trust and a good working relationship.
Example: "I hope you're having a great day! How can I help you today?"
4. **Be positive:** Throughout the call, maintain a positive attitude, even if the conversation is about resolving a problem. Positivity can diffuse tension and create a more productive interaction.
Example: "I'll be happy to look into that issue for you right away."
5. **Take messages:** If the person the caller is trying to reach is unavailable, take down a detailed and accurate message. Include the caller's name, phone number, and a brief reason for the call. Ensure that the message gets to the intended recipient.
6. **Explain your actions:** If you need to put the caller on hold, transfer them, or take any other action, explain what you are doing and why. This ensures the caller isn't left confused or frustrated.
Example: "Let me transfer you to our technical team. They'll be able to assist you better with this issue. Please hold for a moment."

Making Telephone Calls

By adopting the following steps, you can make your telephone calls more effective, professional, and time-efficient, while ensuring clear communication.

1. **Get ready:** Before making the call, ensure you have all the necessary information at hand. This could include notes, relevant documents, or any questions you need to ask. Being prepared makes the call more efficient and professional.

Example: If you're calling a supplier to check on an order, have the order number and details ready to discuss.

2. **Schedule the call:** Whenever possible, schedule a time for the call in advance to ensure the other party is available and ready. This prevents you from calling at an inconvenient time and increases the likelihood of a productive conversation.

Example: "Would you be available for a call tomorrow at 2 p.m. to discuss the project details?"

3. **Minimize distractions:** Before making the call, eliminate background noise and distractions so that you can focus fully on the conversation. This ensures clear communication and shows respect for the person you're calling.

Example: Close your office door, silence notifications, and turn off any other devices that might cause distractions.

4. **Introduce yourself:** Begin the call by stating your name and the purpose of the call. If applicable, also mention your organization. This immediately sets the context for the conversation and puts the other person at ease.

Example: "Hello, this is Sarah from XYZ Marketing. I'm calling to follow up on the proposal we discussed last week."

5. **Maximize your time:** Keep the conversation efficient by staying on topic and moving through the points you need to address. Be polite but avoid unnecessary tangents that could extend the call unnecessarily.

Example: "I'd like to go over the main points of the report and then hear your feedback on the timeline."

6. **Maintain focus:** Throughout the call, stay focused on the conversation. Actively listen to the other person and avoid multitasking. This ensures that you catch all important details and respond appropriately.

Example: Avoid checking emails or typing while speaking. Instead, take notes on the conversation so you don't miss anything.

7. **Use a positive close:** End the call on a positive note by summarizing the key takeaways and confirming any next steps. Thank the person for their time, and ensure they feel good about the outcome of the call.

Example: "Thank you for your time, John. I'll send over the updated draft by tomorrow, and we can plan to meet again next week. Have a great day!"

NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

Nonverbal communication is the process of sending and receiving information, both intentionally and unintentionally, without using language. Nonverbal signals play a vital role in communication because they can strengthen or repeat a verbal message (when the nonverbal signals match the spoken words), weaken or contradict a verbal message (when nonverbal signals don't match the words), or replace words entirely.

Nonverbal signals are a factor in virtually every instance of communication, and they convey a significant portion of the information and emotions shared in interpersonal communication. In a face-to-face conversation, everything from your body language to your clothing to your eye movements can influence the messages and meanings the other party takes away from the exchange. During a phone call, the pitch, rate, and other qualities of your voice can send nonverbal signals. Even with written messages (both printed and digital), design and formatting choices send nonverbal signals.



Nonverbal communication is an intriguing part of business communication because it is complex and often not as straightforward as verbal communication. **On the sending side, some nonverbal signals are controllable (such as choosing what to wear), some are habits you may not even think about (tapping your fingers when you're impatient, for instance), some are trainable (using specific hand gestures during a presentation), and some are involuntary (such as blushing). On the receiving side, while you**

might think you can "read someone like a book," nonverbal signals are not always reliable (a person who avoids eye contact isn't necessarily trying to hide something, for example), and people vary widely in their ability to interpret them correctly.

Types of Nonverbal Communication

In interpersonal communication, six categories of nonverbal signals are particularly important.

- ⊕ **Facial Expressions.** Your face is the primary site for expressing your emotions; it reveals both the type and the intensity of your feelings. Your eyes are especially effective for indicating attention and interest, influencing others, regulating interaction, and establishing dominance. As with other areas of nonverbal expressions, facial signals can vary widely from culture to culture. For instance, maintaining eye contact is usually viewed as a sign of sincerity and openness in the United States, but sustained eye contact is considered disrespectful in many other cultures.
- ⊕ **Gestures, Posture, and Gait.** The way you use your hands, your posture when standing and sitting, and the way you walk send nonverbal signals. Bounding on stage with your head held high sends quite a different message than shuffling up there with your chin down and your hands in your pockets. Leaning forward in your chair is a way to let someone know you're paying attention. Adapting a "power posture," such as standing with your chin up, your hands on your hips, and your feet spread or leaning forward with your hands on a table or desk can make you feel more confident and convey a message of confidence. However, these shows of strength can also intimidate other people and discourage them from opening up.
- ⊕ **Vocal Characteristics.** Voice carries both intentional and unintentional messages. A speaker can intentionally control pitch, pace, and stress to convey a specific message. For instance, compare **"What are you doing?"** and **"What are you doing?"** Unintentional vocal characteristics can convey happiness, surprise, fear, and other emotions. For example, fear often increases the pitch and the pace of your voice. Most listeners are acutely sensitive to the way others speak, so make sure the tone of your voice matches the messages you mean to send.
- ⊕ **Personal Appearance.** People respond to others on the basis of their physical appearance, sometimes fairly and other times unfairly. Although an individual's body type and facial features impose limitations, most people are able to control their appearance to some degree. Grooming, clothing, accessories, piercings, tattoos, hairstyle — you can

control all of these. Many employers also have guidelines concerning attire, body art, and other issues, so make sure you understand and follow them.

- ⊕ **Touch.** Touch is an important way to convey warmth, comfort, and reassurance — as well as control. Touch is so powerful, in fact, that it is governed by cultural customs that establish who can touch whom and how in various circumstances. In the United States and Great Britain, for instance, people usually touch less frequently than people in France or Costa Rica do. Even within each culture's norms, however, individual attitudes toward touch vary widely. A manager might be comfortable using hugs to express support or congratulations, but his or her subordinates could interpret those hugs as a show of dominance or sexual interest. Touch is a complex subject. The best advice: When in doubt, don't touch.
- ⊕ **Time and Space.** Like touch, time and space can be used to assert authority, show respect, imply intimacy, and send other nonverbal messages. For instance, the distance at which people are comfortable conversing with others varies widely based on their relationships with them (and their culture, to a degree). You might be fine with family members standing a foot or two away, but you probably prefer work colleagues to stand or sit several feet away whenever possible and strangers to keep even farther away.

Maximizing Nonverbal Communication

By understanding and managing your nonverbal communication, you can enhance your message and create a more positive and effective interaction. Following are some of the steps you can follow.

1. **Avoid conflicting signals.** Ensure that your body language matches your verbal communication. Sending mixed messages can confuse or mislead others.
Example: Saying "I'm open to your suggestions" while crossing your arms may indicate defensiveness, which conflicts with the message of openness.
2. **Strive for honesty.** Your nonverbal cues should reflect your true feelings. People can often detect insincerity through body language.
Example: If you're not happy with a proposal, nodding or smiling to appear agreeable can create confusion later when you voice concerns.
3. **Smile genuinely.** A genuine smile conveys warmth and approachability. It helps in building rapport and creating a positive environment.
Example: Smiling during an introduction helps ease tension and makes the other person feel welcomed.
4. **Maintain eye contact.** Appropriate eye contact shows confidence, interest, and respect, but be mindful not to stare, which can make others uncomfortable.
Example: Maintaining regular eye contact during a meeting shows you're engaged in the conversation.
5. **Be aware of posture and gestures.** Posture and gestures reveal much about your attitude. Stand or sit up straight to project confidence, and avoid overly aggressive or defensive gestures.
Example: Leaning slightly forward while speaking shows interest, while slouching can indicate disengagement.

6. **Use appropriate vocal signals.** Your tone, pitch, and volume should complement the message you're delivering. Speaking too softly can make you seem uncertain, while speaking too loudly may seem aggressive.
Example: Lowering your voice to emphasize a point can convey seriousness and draw attention to important information.
7. **Know your audience.** Different audiences may interpret nonverbal cues differently based on cultural norms or individual preferences.
Example: In some cultures, direct eye contact is a sign of respect, while in others, it might be considered confrontational.
8. **Acknowledge comfort zones.** Be mindful of personal space, as invading someone's comfort zone can make them feel uneasy.
Example: Standing too close to someone during a conversation might make them feel uncomfortable, especially in cultures where personal space is highly valued.
9. **Shake hands appropriately.** A firm, but not too strong, handshake conveys confidence, while a weak handshake may come off as disinterest.
Example: A brief, firm handshake during a business introduction sets a professional tone, while avoiding it could come off as rude.
10. **Respect varying attitudes about time.** Nonverbal cues related to time — like punctuality or how much time you allow for a conversation — can carry different meanings in various cultures.
Example: In some cultures, being a few minutes late may be acceptable, while in others, punctuality is highly valued.
11. **Use touch carefully.** In some cultures or situations, touch is a sign of warmth and familiarity, while in others, it can be seen as inappropriate.
Example: A light tap on the shoulder can be encouraging, but avoid physical contact in formal business settings unless it's culturally appropriate.
12. **Be aware of false cues.** Don't jump to conclusions based solely on nonverbal cues, as sometimes they can be misleading.
Example: Someone crossing their arms may simply be cold, not defensive, so it's important to consider the context.

REVIEW AND DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

A. Theoretical/Conceptual Questions

1. What is collaboration?
2. What are some advantages of teams?
3. What are some disadvantages of teams?
4. What is groupthink?
5. What are the most significant characteristics of effective teams?
6. Can conflict be a good thing for teams?
7. Write about the conflict management styles with examples.
8. How can one effectively prepare for meetings?
9. Everyone in a meeting shares the responsibility for keeping the meeting productive and making it successful. If you are the designated leader of a meeting, however, you have an extra degree of responsibility and accountability. To ensure productive meetings, what steps can be followed?
10. Explain the listening process.
11. Write about some of the barriers to effective listening.
12. What is selective listening?
13. What is selective perception?
14. What techniques can be followed to ensure effective listening?
15. Write about telephone etiquettes in terms of receiving and making phone calls.
16. Explain the different types of nonverbal communication.
17. How can one maximize nonverbal communication?

B. Situational/Contextual Questions

1. You head up the interdepartmental design review team for a manufacturer of high-performance motorcycles, and things are not going well at the moment. The design engineers and marketing strategists keep arguing about which should be a higher priority, performance or aesthetics, and the accountants say both groups are driving up the cost of the new model by adding too many new features. Everyone has valid points to make, but the team is getting bogged down in conflict. Explain how you could go about resolving the stalemate.
2. Several members of your sales team are protesting the company's "business casual" dress code, claiming that dressing nicely makes them feel awkward and overly formal in front of customers. You have to admit that most of the company's customers dress like they've just walked in from a picnic or a bike ride, but that doesn't change the fact that you want your company to be seen as conscientious and professional. How will you explain the policy to these employees in a way that will help them understand and accept it?
3. Why do you think people are more likely to engage in rude behaviors during online communication than during in person communication?
4. You're giving your first major presentation at your new job and you notice at least half the people in the small conference room are looking at their mobile devices more than they are looking at you. How should you handle the situation?

C. Improve Your Grammar, Mechanics, and Usage

Use the following self-assessment exercises to improve your knowledge of and power over English grammar, mechanics, and usage.

Level 1: Self-Assessment—Pronouns

For the following items, replace the underlined nouns with the correct pronouns.

1. To which retailer will you send your merchandise?
2. Have you given Javier and Nancy a list of parts?
3. The main office sent the invoice to Mr. and Mrs. Litvak on December 5.
4. The company settled the company's accounts before the end of the year.
5. Which person's umbrella is this?

For the following items, identify which of the pronoun forms provided in parentheses is correct.

6. The sales staff is preparing guidelines for (their, its) clients.
7. Few of the sales representatives turn in (their, its) reports on time.
8. The board of directors has chosen (their, its) officers.
9. Johnstone and Koseff have told (his, their) clients about the new program.
10. Each manager plans to expand (his, their, his or her) sphere of control next year.
11. Has everyone supplied (his, their, his or her) Social Security number?
12. After giving every employee (his, their, a) raise, George told (them, they, all) about the increased workload.
13. Cherise and Tim have opposite ideas about how to achieve company goals. (Who, Whom) do you think will win the debate?
14. City Securities has just announced (who, whom) it will hire as CEO.
15. Either of the new products would readily find (their, its) niche in the marketplace.

Level 2: Workplace Applications

The following items may contain errors in grammar, capitalization, punctuation, abbreviation, number style, word division, and vocabulary. Rewrite each sentence, correcting all errors. If a sentence has no errors, write "Correct" for that number.

16. Anita Doig from Data Providers will outline their data interpretations as it relates to industry trends, additionally Miss Doig will be asked to comment on how their data should be utilized.
17. You're order for 2000 mylar bags has been received by us; please be advised that orders of less than 5000 bags only get a 20 percent discount.
18. Just between you and I, the new 'customer centric' philosophy seems pretty confusing.
19. Podcasting can be an effective way to distribute messages to a widespread audience, but you need to pay close attention to the demands of an audio medium.
20. Among the specialties of Product Marketers International is promotional efforts for clients, including presence on the Internet, radio, and on television.
21. An overview of a typical marketing plan will be covered in the introduction to this report, to give you an idea of what's in it.
22. Subsidiary rights sales can be a discreet source of income and compliment your overall sales.
23. Special events ranging from author breakfasts and luncheons to awards programs and reception's offers a great way to make industry contacts.
24. We will show you how not only to meet the challenges of information rich material but also the challenges of electronic distance learning.
25. To site just one problem, the reason that the market is in such a state of confusion is the appalling lack of standards whether for hardware, software or for metadata.
26. Two leading business consultants Tadashi Son and Carla McNeil will share their insights on how specialty stores can effectively compete in a world of Corporate Superstores.
27. One of the big questions we need to address are "How does buying effect inventory levels"?
28. The closing of many industry digital entities have greatly affected the perception of e-books as a viable platform.
29. A competent, motivated, and enthusiastic staff can be a managers' most important asset in a competitive marketplace.
30. Come by the Technology Lounge where you can log on to computers and plugin laptops and check out demos of sponsor's websites.